to pass by a ‘cat’, a spotter who was a former terrorist. Anyone identified and pointed out by the cat was segregated and questioned separately.

I considered targeting and influencing the minds of the people more important than catching or killing a few terrorists. Winning their hearts and minds with the velvet-glove approach and a humane touch was an important facet of counter-insurgency operations in my command. My talk and interaction with the people, conducted in Urdu, would go something like this:

Kashmir Valley, 1991–92

Dear brothers and fellow Kashmiris. I feel sorry to put you through the inconvenience caused by the crackdown (the name given by the locals to a cordon-and-search operation). But were it not on account of the reported presence of terrorists in this area, we wouldn’t be here.

We are the army of the people, and are here for your security. You are our countrymen, and I firmly believe that over 95 per cent of you are innocent. My troops will treat you with respect and your dignity will be upheld. There shall be no misbehaviour with women, harassment of the children and the elderly people, or wilful damage and destruction of your property.

Terrorism has turned your beautiful state into a veritable hell. God had given you a paradise. What will your children inherit from your generation? Maybe a generation or two would never see peace and prosperity. Progress will remain a chimera. Without your cooperation, terrorism cannot be rooted out. Look at Mizoram and Punjab. It was only when the people stopped supporting the terrorists, peace could prevail. Those people are now enjoying the ‘peace dividend’. Do the terrorists realize or care as to how much damage they are causing to their own community?

I hear your refrain very often, ‘Jenaab, ham to aapki aur jehadi bandook ke beech me mare ja rahe hai’ *(Sir, we are caught in between two guns, one of the army and the other of the jehadi). I can say with confidence that we are fully responsible and accountable, ‘jimmewar’ and ‘jawabdar’, as far as our actions are concerned, but the same cannot be said for the jehadis. If you don’t display courage, nothing will change. Put up a united stand – they dare not even touch you as long as you are all together.*

What is it that they are promising you, ‘Azaadi’*? It is not so, as they have an ‘agenda’ of their own. What ‘azaadi’ are they talking about? With just a flag, a small landlocked*